

The Pharisee & The Tax Collector



SCRIPTURE · Luke 18:9–14

The Pharisee & The Tax Collector · ESV

MAIN MESSAGE

God does not justify those who trust in their own religious performance, no matter how devout they appear. He approves the heart that comes in humble contrition, repentance, and faith. True righteousness is never earned by our efforts but received only through acknowledging our sin and appealing to God's mercy, which He delights to give to the humble.

DISCOVERY QUESTIONS

- 01** Do you approach God trusting in your own performance or humbly trusting in Him? Why?
- 02** Where has discipline or consistency led you toward pride instead of dependence on God?

Discovering Truth

Jesus tells this parable to people who believed they were right with God because of how they lived. These were disciplined, moral men who built their identity on doing the right things while quietly looking down on others. This is not a story about obvious failure—it is about hidden pride. Jesus exposes the reality that a man can look strong on the outside and still be completely disconnected from God if his confidence is in himself.

01 · PARABLE ONE

The Pharisee

The Pharisee represents outward strength with inward pride. He is disciplined, consistent, and respected, and by every external measure, his life looks right. But when he prays, he is not seeking God—he is presenting himself. His confidence is built on performance, and he measures his worth by comparing himself to other men. That comparison fuels pride and creates distance from God. A man can build a strong life externally and still be completely disconnected if his identity is rooted in what he does.

02 · PARABLE TWO

The Tax Collector

The tax collector represents honest humility. He is not respected and carries the weight of his sin, but he does not hide it or manage it. He comes to God aware of his need, without comparison or defense. His prayer is simple: 'Be merciful to me.' He brings nothing but his need, and Jesus makes it clear that this is the man who is made right with God is humble in repentance and faith, not performance, is what opens the door to grace.

Jesus makes it clear that the humble man is justified, not the impressive one. To be justified means to be declared right before God, not because of performance, but because of dependence. Through Jesus, the way is opened for men not to earn their place, but to receive it. Pride will always block grace because it convinces a man he doesn't need it. But when a man comes honestly, humbly, and surrendered, grace meets him there. The question is not how strong you look, but how you come before God.

Key Points

01

You can look strong on the outside and still be far from God if your confidence is in your performance.

02

Pride builds distance from God, while honest humility opens the door to grace.

03

You are not made right with God by what you do, but by how you come—dependent, honest, and surrendered.

GROUP DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

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| 01 Where are you comparing yourself to other men instead of examining your own heart? | 04 What is keeping you from fully embracing humility before God? |
| 02 Where do you struggle to be honest about your need before God? | 05 How would your relationship with God change if you stopped trying to prove yourself? |
| 03 Do you relate more to the Pharisee or the tax collector in this parable right now, and why? | |

Personal Reflection

Most men won't say they're like the Pharisee, but many live like him. You build your life on discipline and trying to be a 'good person,' and over time, you start believing that's what makes you right with God. That's where pride takes over. You compare, measure, and turn your relationship with God into something you feel you need to earn. But the tax collector shows the truth—you bring nothing but your need. You don't earn your standing. You don't outperform your sin. You come honest, aware, and humble.

PERSONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

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| 01 Who do you find yourself comparing against, and what is that producing in you? | 03 In your environment (team, work, family), where are you tempted to look down on others? |
| 02 What is one area of pride you need to bring before God honestly this week? | 04 What would it look like for you to lead with humility instead of image this week? |